



THERE'S SOME QUESTIONS GOT ANSWERS AND SOME HAVEN'T

PICNIC AT HANGING ROCK / 1975

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Mystery drama

DIRECTOR

Peter Weir

WRITERS

**Cliff Green (screenplay);
Joan Lindsay (novel)**

STARS

Rachel Roberts, Anne-Louise Lambert, Vivean Gray, Helen Morse

BEFORE

1974 Weir's first feature, *The Cars That Ate Paris*, develops his trademark theme of macabre happenings in a small community.

AFTER

1981 Like *Hanging Rock*, *Gallipoli*, Weir's World War I drama, authentically captures Edwardian Australia.

1989 Weir's acclaimed US drama, *Dead Poets Society*, echoes *Hanging Rock* in its story of a tragedy at a school.

Picnic at *Hanging Rock* opens with a caption stating that on February 14, 1900, a party of schoolgirls went on a picnic at Hanging Rock near Mount Macedon in the Australian state of Victoria. It ends with the words: "During the afternoon several members of the party disappeared without a trace." This creates the impression that the story that follows is based on true events—but it isn't. The movie, made in 1975, is entirely fictitious.

So why are the words there? Are they a trick, or a clue—or both? This is the first of many

mysteries posed in this haunting Valentine's Day trip into the wilds of the Australian bush.

No resolution

The strange events at Hanging Rock were first related in a 1967 novel by Australian author Joan Lindsay, which itself was ambiguous about whether the case of the missing party was true. When Weir came to adapt the book for movie, he faced an unusual challenge: Lindsay had offered no explanation for the story's central mystery. The three girls and their teacher simply vanish—there is no suggestion of where they go, or why. Could the director expect his audience to sit through a two-hour mystery that has no resolution? Weir's response was to draw out themes of absence—not only do the girls and Miss McCraw, their teacher, disappear early in the story, but no solutions or clues are found to the questions asked. Another teacher, Mr. Whitehead (Frank Gunnell), is the first to accept that the event is unsolvable—"There's some questions got answers and some haven't," he says simply. In *Picnic at Hanging Rock*, Weir is

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A movie composed almost entirely of clues. It forces us to stretch our imaginations.

Vincent Canby

The New York Times, 1979

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